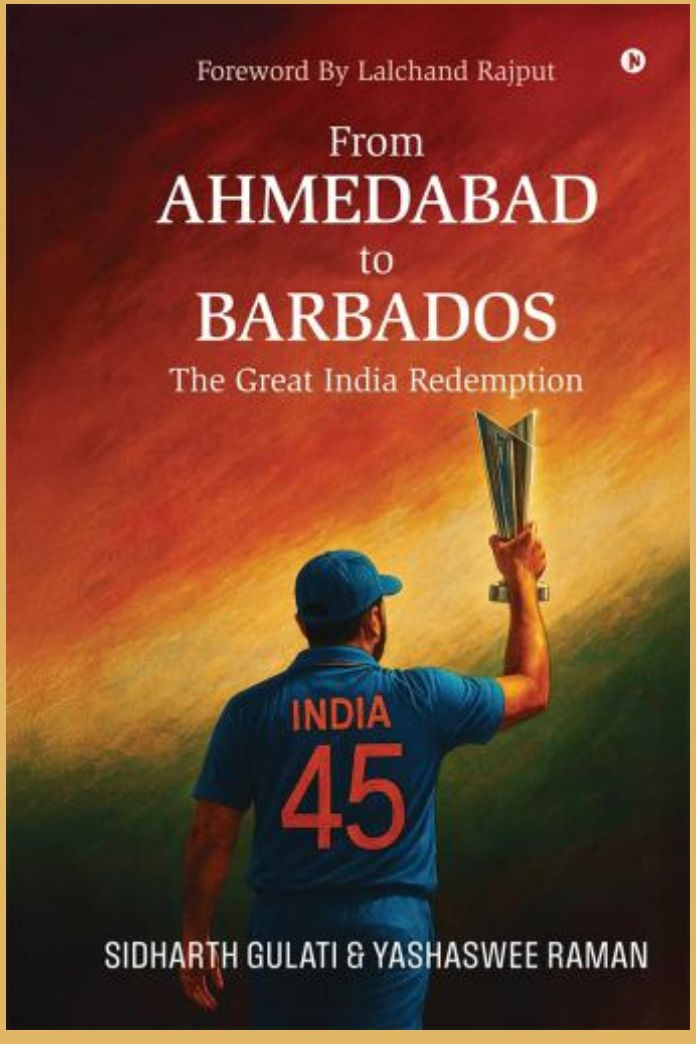
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MY POWAI

Volume No. 14 Issue No. 04 Mumbai December 2025

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Dear friends

As the year folds into its final chapter, I catch myself pausing, wondering how swiftly the months have flown. It feels as though we blinked, and suddenly winter has arrived—wrapping the city in a gentler rhythm and inviting reflection, warmth and celebration.

This December issue is shaped by that spirit of reflection and warmth. Our nutrition expert brings a thoughtful Winter Wellness Guide to help you stay healthy and energized through the season. In our recipe section, savour the Flavours of Bengal—a comforting culinary journey filled with nostalgia. The Astro pages return with guidance for the year ahead, and our feature on The 7 Money Vows That Will Build Wealth offers practical wisdom for stepping into 2026 with clarity and confidence.

As always, our pages carry the pulse of the neighbourhood—local news, meaningful updates, and stories that keep our community connected and informed.

To every reader who has supported us this year with encouragement, feedback, and shared enthusiasm—thank you. Your belief turns every issue into a conversation worth having.

See you in the New Year—refreshed, hopeful, and ready for new stories.

Warm regards,
Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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BMC uses every penny in the coffers.

(Kal kya hoga kisko pata)



D.P.K. Udas

As it is evident the elections of the civic body of Mumbai are likely to be announced soon.

Once such elections are announced there would be "Code of Conduct" and new orders/tenders would not be finalized.

In view of this there has been flurry of activities of Procurement in the BMC.
BMC is going to resurface EEH and WEH by mastic compound.
They will spend following amounts
EEH – Rs 63 crores
WEH – Rs 74 crores

The irony is that roads belong to MSRDC and repair cost is being borne by BMC. The requirements seem to be generated by "Jor Jabardasti" Some of the OTHER requirements are listed below

1. Fabrication of Parking Shed. (The scope is only supply and erection will be done after elections)
2. Cleaning of roads and surrounding areas (As such this is a routine activity.)
3. House Keeping contract from "registered vendors" Lottery system for allotting work.
4. Cleaning of toilets 5 times a day.
5. Supply of FRP toilets
6. Printing of various size posters /flex / banners.
7. Supply of T-shirt
8. Supply of manhole covers & MS Gratings
9. Supply of bleaching powder
10. Mosquito proofing of water tanks
11. Providing Anti-Skid floor mats.
12. Supply of Polypropylene sheet
13. Procurement of Laptop.
14. Providing Binding of Calendar etc.

Now there are 2 routes of procurement
1. Tenders
2. Quotation



Once tender is floated then it has to go through eligibility criteria and it takes time.

Also, tender participation can be from anyone as it is public tender. There is competitive pressure.

In case of Quotations it is given to only "registered suppliers". Offers are received from limited known parties and procurement is finalized quickly.

The above list of 14 items is being procured by Quotation route only.

Further if we see nature of procurement it is only supply of various standard items which are available easily in the market. The contract can be finalized and executed quickly.

As far as Powai is concerned there are following things which are priority and they seem to have not been covered in these **hurried procurements.**

1. Provision of bulbs for street lighting
2. The overall cleanliness.
3. While G/South ward has been floating tenders for maintaining general cleanliness there is no such tender in "S" ward and "L" ward.
4. Resurfacing of roads
5. Painting of Zebra crossing
6. Provision of non-metallic garbage bins.
7. Maintenance of "Nirmalya Kalash" at Powai lake.
8. Restarting of fountain at Powai Lake.
9. Dust Suction System
10. Display of quality of air including AQI.

The spending of BMC needs to be conservative.

They need to also look at the taxation imposed by them and need to look at other avenues of income.

Finally, there is no democratic voice today. The absence of Corporator leaves general public with the option of only writing letters about their grievances.

We hope that good sense will prevail and there would be improvement.

As the popular punch line is "One has to shell out money even to take a breath in Mumbai"

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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An evening of Music, Memories & Marathi pride at Maan Vandana



Chaitra Shri Marathi Mandal organised Maan Vandana—a tribute to Marathi artistes and playwrights—on the occasion of Diwali at Zodiac Hall, Florentine, Powai.

The presenter was Vighnesh Joshi, a renowned Marathi actor with several plays to his credit. He was accompanied by Kalyani Joshi, a trained classical singer and an accomplished tabla player. Together, they paid tribute to legendary Marathi artistes from various fields, such as Ram Ganesh Gadkari, Kusumagraj, Vidyadhar Gokhale, Bal Kolhatkar, Purushottam Darvekar, Srinivas Khale, Acharya Atre, P. L. Deshpande, Manik Verma, Sulochana Chavan, and many more.

Vighnesh Joshi narrated interesting incidents behind each composition before Kalyani Joshi presented the songs, making the evening engaging and filled with humour. The concert lasted for one and a half hours, mesmerizing the audience—many of whom had come specially for the program.

A quiz was also conducted, and the winner received a can of mango pulp, a playful nod to Vighnesh Joshi's mango business. He appealed to the audience to continue supporting musical programs and to encourage the younger generation.

The air-conditioned hall was beautifully decorated with lights. Guests were welcomed with Haldi-Kumkum, rose water perfume, and a Chafa flower. The program concluded with dinner, and members left happily after the Diwali celebration.

Chaitra Shri Marathi Mandal Powai committee members—Rashmi, Vidya, Shaila, and Minal—regularly organise musical programs at Zodiac Hall, Florentine.

- Preeti Oka

Overflowing garbage, encroached footpaths: the crisis we can't ignore



The story of Powai and Chandivali today is one of slow erosion — not through storms or floods, but through neglect. What were once clean, thoughtfully planned neighbourhoods now wrestle with problems that should never have been allowed to grow this large.

Overflowing garbage bins have become a grim symbol across Powai. Placed dangerously close to residential pockets, these bins spill their contents onto the streets whenever the BMC misses collection — and that happens far too often. The heaps rot in broad daylight, filling the air with a foul stench and inviting stray animals, pests, and disease. It is not just unpleasant; it is a serious health hazard.

Along Chandivali Farm Road, the situation is even more disturbing. The entire stretch from the temple to Gundecha stands buried under garbage that has been lying there for months. Complaints have been made repeatedly, yet the silence in response is deafening. It raises a difficult question — why have citizens been forced to accept such decay as normal?

Adding to the crisis is rampant footpath encroachment, which has choked pedestrian movement and compromised public safety. Food vendors now occupy every available inch of pavement. Outside Boomerang, carts line up in a buzzing row, doing brisk business without hygiene standards, without permits, and without any tax compliance. Even well-dressed executives line up there, ignoring the obvious risks.

Powai faces a similar reality. Just a few feet from Hotel The Beatle, stalls crowd the sidewalk, mirroring Chandivali's chaos. No systems, no checks, no accountability — and sadly, civic authorities continue to look away.

Corporator's elections are around the corner. Soon, leaders will come seeking votes, promising change. But unless voters demand action now — clean footpaths, responsible waste management, enforcement without bias — the next five years will look no different.

Powai and Chandivali deserve better. It is time to reclaim our streets, our health, and our dignity.

Your 7 money vows — the saath phere that build wealth

Just like the Saath Phere guide a couple into a life of commitment, trust, and shared responsibility, our financial journey too is shaped by the vows we keep — and the ones we unintentionally break.

Most money problems don't come from a lack of income. They come from small habits that quietly push life off track.

Rohan Mehta was living exactly this way. He earned well, took care of his family, and saved "whenever he remembered to." But like many of us, he didn't realise that unplanned decisions today turn into heavy consequences tomorrow.

These are the 7 money vows Rohan unknowingly broke — until a turning point changed everything.

1. Borrowing for the wrong dreams

Rohan took a loan for an international vacation. The trip ended, but the EMIs didn't. He later admitted, "I paid for Europe long after the photos stopped giving joy."

2. Chasing shortcuts to wealth

A colleague shared a "sure-shot" stock tip. The profits never came — only stress did.

3. Playing with fire without knowing the heat

He tried margin trading without understanding the risks. A small market dip led to a margin call he wasn't prepared for.

7 RULES YOU SHOULD NEVER BREAK

(YOUR WEALTH WILL THANK YOU)

1. Don't swipe EMIs for things that lose value.
2. Don't fall for "get rich quick."
3. Don't chase stock tips.
4. Don't let emotions drive money decisions.
5. Don't wait for the "right time" to save.
6. Don't run after hot stocks or fads.
7. Don't forget Rules 1–6.

4. Letting fear drive decisions

During a market crash, he exited his equity investments. The market recovered — his portfolio didn't.

5. Waiting for the perfect time

He kept delaying SIPs, thinking he'd start "next month." Months turned into years. Compounding only helps those who begin.

6. Running after yesterday's winners

He invested in last year's top-performing fund. The next year, it wasn't even in the top 10. He realised discipline beats excitement.

7. The turning point

One evening, staring at scattered investments and growing responsibilities, Rohan finally admitted:

"I need a plan, not random actions."

He shifted from chasing shortcuts to following a structured, guided financial plan. Today, he invests calmly, confidently, and with purpose — not pressure.

As Warren Buffett said,

"You only have to do a very few things right in your life, as long as you don't do too many things wrong."

Wealth isn't built by brilliance.

It's built by avoiding mistakes, staying patient, and letting money work quietly in the background.

- Uma Kumaravelan
Certified Financial Planner
www.oaktree.in



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MapleLeaf Badminton Tournament 2025: Two days full of sport, music and community get-togethers

Like every year Maple Leaf Sports Community hosted a badminton tournament on 1st Nov and 2nd Nov. 2025 in their society's play courts, bringing together a vibrant community of *550 families and 1800+ members* that includes UBI Bank employees, corporates, entrepreneurs, and public servants. The event blended exciting matches with great sportsmanship, upbeat music, tasty food, and true community fun.

Event Highlights
Format and Participation: 40+ registrations across Men's Doubles, Women's Doubles, and Mixed Doubles, with more than 40 matches spanning qualifiers, quarterfinals, semifinals and finals.

Opening Ceremony
Graced by Sunil Vaidya, former cricketer and independent commentator and Society Chairperson Mrs. Kukreja set the tone with inspiring words on sportsmanship and community spirit.

Community Vibes
Non-stop music, delicious bites, and neighbors cheering from the sidelines created a festival atmosphere throughout both days.

Partners and Sponsors
A heartfelt thank you to our partners and sponsors whose support made the event seamless and memorable:
UBI Bank
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LifeMart
Total Sports
NK Diamonds
Looks Saloon Powai
Anushka Polyclinic
Baroque – Arts Partner
MyPowai – Media Partner
Satkar Kitchens – F&B Partner
JS Thind & Family
Sanjith Sir – Badminton Coach & Mentor

Dignitaries at the Closing Ceremony
Our closing ceremony brought together distinguished guests who facilitated awards and celebrated the spirit of the games, calling a successful close to the tournament:
Mr. KM Reddy (GM IT, UBI Bank)
Mr. Shikar (CEO, RIPPL)
Mr. Nilesh (CEO, NK Diamonds)
Mr. Neeraj & Ms. Shalaka (CEO, LifeMart)
Mr. Omkar (Marketing Director, Total Sports)
Mr. Manoj (CEO, Anushka Polyclinic)
Mr. Harish (CEO, Satkar Kitchens)
Mr. Raj Shah (Art Director, Baroque)
MyPowai

Winners
Men's Doubles
Winners: Sidhant & Vedant
1st Runner-up: Nilesh & Vijay
2nd Runner-up: Neeraj & Ronak

Women's Doubles
Group A Winners: Bhakti & Deepti
Group B Winners: Richa & Pooja

Mixed Doubles
Group A Winners: Bhakti & Vijay
Group A Runner-up: Kalpana & Vedant

Group B Winners: Aditi & Abhishek
Group B Runner-up: Aishwarya & Vidyanand

Promising Players of the Tournament
Women: Purnya (Guddu)
Men: Avinash

Gratitude and Closing
From spirited rallies and nail-biting finishes to friendly smiles and shared meals, the tournament showcased what makes the MapleLeaf Society special: a strong, inclusive community where sport brings everyone together. Congratulations to all winners and participants, and a big thank you to our partners, sponsors, coaches, volunteers, and organizing committee for making it a resounding success.










The lantern maker's apprentice: a parable on HOPE



Debika Chaudhuri

In a small town tucked between mountains and mist lived a young boy named Sora. He worked as an apprentice to **Master Yuki,** an old lantern maker whose lanterns glowed warmer and longer than anyone else's. People whispered that he used a secret oil or magical wick, but Sora knew the truth: Master Yuki simply understood light differently.

Sora, however, was losing his own light. His father had recently fallen ill, their home felt heavy with worry, and school had become a blur of fear and fatigue. He carried these clouds with him everywhere.

One morning, noticing the boy's drooping shoulders, Master Yuki handed him an unfinished lantern.

"Today," he said, "you will create a **lantern of Hope."**
Sora frowned. "But how? I've only made ordinary lanterns."
"That is exactly why you must learn this now," Master Yuki replied. "A lantern of Hope requires a different kind of light."
He guided Sora to a dusty shelf where three objects lay: a **cracked clay pot**, a **rusty compass**, and a **tiny seed**.
"Choose one," he said, "and I will show you how it becomes light."
Unsure, Sora picked up the cracked clay pot.
Master Yuki nodded. "Good. Let me tell you a story."

The Cracked Pot
"Once," he began, "a pot was ashamed of the crack along its side. It leaked water every day on the long walk from the river. Feeling broken and useless, it apologised to its owner. But the owner simply smiled and pointed to the path blooming with flowers.
'Your crack watered these flowers all year,' he said.
Hope works the same way.
You may feel broken, but your cracks may be nurturing someone else's garden or preparing the soil of your own future."
Sora thought of the cracks in his heart, fear for his father, anxiety about school, uncertainty about tomorrow. Could something quietly be growing because of all this?

Sora then pointed to the rusty compass. "And what about this?"

The Rusty Compass
Master Yuki lifted it gently. "A compass rusts when it is not used. Worry and despair do the same to our inner direction. But the moment you take even one step of courage, the needle wakes and begins pointing forward.
In Buddhism, we say: **the moment you believe in your ability to change your life, the universe begins to move with you.**
Hope is that first moment."
Sora felt something shift inside him like a needle trembling toward north.
Finally, he touched the tiny seed.



Image courtesy: Macmac Malt

The Tiny Seed
Master Yuki grinned. "Ah! The seed of **Emotional Intelligence.**"
Sora raised an eyebrow. "A seed?"
"Yes. Hope is like this seed," the master explained. "It doesn't transform the soil instantly. But when planted daily through effort, prayer, compassion, and learning it grows roots of **self-awareness** and leaves of **self-regulation**.

When you hope for your father's recovery, you become more patient at home.
When you hope for a better tomorrow, you speak kinder words today.
When you hope for the best in others, you listen more deeply.
And like compound interest, these tiny hopeful acts grow into a forest."

Crafting the Lantern
Master Yuki guided him to place pieces of the cracked pot, the metal from the compass, and the shell of the seed into the lantern's frame.
"These," he said, "are the materials of hope: **your wounds, your direction, and your potential.**
When you combine them with consistent action, they glow."
When Sora lit the finished lantern, a warm steady flame flickered to life, neither too bright nor weak, simply alive. Something within him softened. The heaviness didn't disappear, but it loosened, like winter snow beginning to drip into spring.

The Compounded Effect
Sora placed the lantern by his window that night. Over the following days, he found himself:
• speaking gently to his father
• helping classmates who struggled
• practicing lantern-making with renewed focus
• praying with sincerity
• approaching problems not as walls, but as places to grow
People began to say Sora's face looked like "sunrise after a long night."

One evening, Master Yuki stood beside him and whispered:
"Remember: **Winter always turns to spring.**
Your role is simply to keep the lantern lit until it does."
Sora looked at his lantern, then at his own heart, and finally understood.
Hope isn't a wish.
Hope is a craft.
And every day, you are its maker.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

The Old Guard



Chaarvi Athawale

There was a time when Powai felt like the neighbourhood equivalent of a well-brewed chamomile tea, calm, golden, and capable of lowering blood pressure on sight. The pathways were quiet, the parks were pristine, and the loudest thing around was a mildly opinionated parrot or a particularly enthusiastic myna.

Then, over the years, Powai slowly transformed. Not dramatically enough for anyone to sound an alarm, but just enough for old-timers to look around and think, "Hmm, this wasn't here in 2010." It's the kind of change where you cannot pinpoint the exact moment things shifted, you just wake up one day and notice that the neighbourhood has developed… a pulse. A thumpingly loud one.

The demographic tilt is undeniable. Powai's older residents, the pioneers who arrived when Hiranandani brochures were still glossy with promise, now form a sizable senior population. Many live alone while their children build lives in foreign lands with colder weather and better tap water. Powai was supposed to be the quiet, well-maintained retirement plan. These days, it's more of a humming, overstuffed compromise.

Not to mention the influx. New and younger residents with fast jobs, fast deliveries, fast sneakers, and fast metabolism. They slot neatly into Powai's newer buildings, carrying laptops, gym bags, and an encyclopaedic knowledge of artisanal coffee. It's not that they are disruptive; the population density is. At some point, the neighbourhood will simply run out of quiet to give.



Traffic is Powai's other visible plot twist. Once upon a time, Eden Lane and Galleria were practically Instagram filters: soft lighting, minimal clutter, dreamy ambience, the works. Today, they are auditioning for the role of "Best Supporting Congestion" in the upcoming city awards. The problem lies in multiplication: more homes, same roads. It's urban mathematics, with a pitiful sense of humour.

The parks tell their own whimsical tragedy. Once privately maintained and pampered like delicate heirlooms, many were later declared public-access spaces. Inclusivity is noble. Overuse is predictable. The grass looks like it's been through a war with itself every night. Chip packets, candy wrappers, bits of takeout strewn everywhere: everyone wants a piece of Powai's greenery, and the greenery is politely trying not to scream.

Meanwhile, political branding has spread across Powai with hoardings sprouting, banners blooming overnight like civic mushrooms. Visually startling for a neighbourhood that once looked like a neo-classical marvel, now festooned with party representatives wishing us every festival in advance.

Cleanliness, once Powai's flex, is now a bit more… interpretive. Certain lanes sport arrangements of cigarette butts and open garbage bins. Footpaths have suddenly developed "character" with garbage mounds left piling around for days.



These little shifts, these frayed edges, tend to settle most heavily on the people who've stayed long enough to recognise them. They are the ones who navigate the uneven bits with quiet patience, who remember a version of Powai that didn't require so much negotiation. They don't complain or are simply tired of doing so, which is precisely why someone else should.

Because neighbourhoods don't always need big fixes; sometimes they just need someone to put the bench back. The small repairs, the routine cleaning, the quiet dignity of maintenance, these are the gestures that make a place gentler for the people who carried it through its calmer years.

If Powai truly prides itself on progress, then surely it can manage the simplest kind of it: taking care of the Old Guard who took care of it first.

PALADIN 2025

"Champions keep playing until they get it right"



In a spectacular display of talent and intellect, our students Mst Vyankatesh Wakale and Mst Nishit Lulle from Gopal Sharma International School, emerged victorious at the Regional Level securing the second position BKJ held on 16th November,2025. The qualifying rounds had the students bag the first prize at the Bharat Vikas Parishad, Powai, Chandivali branch, winner of the 'Bharat ko Jano' contest held earlier.

The junior team represented the Mumbai Konkan prant and participated in the West region BKJ in Nagpur held on Sunday. This competition is a quiz programme for the school children to increase their awareness about the distinctive features of our country and culture. The students outstanding performance multifaceted skills secured them the coveted title.

Their achievements bring laurels not only to the school, but also to our city and state. Our young stars exceeded all expectations and brought delighted shivers down our spines. Their performance was a true testament to their unwavering dedication, passion and exceptional talent.

All in all, it was a wonderful and innovative platform for students to explore. We heartily congratulate and appreciate their contribution in adding another feather to the success and the pride of our school.

- Shraddha Malpekar

The science behind Indian food's unique and delicious flavours

Every Mumbai kitchen has a rhythm. You can hear the sizzle of spices in hot oil, smell the roasted cumin, and feel the warmth of fresh chapatis on the plate. Behind these familiar sights and smells is a lot of science.



Indian food stands out because it is built on contrast. Most cuisines pair similar flavours together, but Indian cooking does the opposite. A study by researchers at IIT Jodhpur showed that our recipes often combine ingredients with very different flavour compounds. That is why butter chicken feels rich yet tangy, and chaat balances sweet, sour, spicy, and crunchy all at once. Our brains enjoy variety. The clash of flavours keeps every bite exciting.

The cooking process itself is also a science in motion. When we fry onions or garlic, the heat breaks down sugars and proteins.

This creates new compounds that add that deep brown colour and savoury aroma. The process is called the Maillard reaction. It is the same one that makes toast golden or gives coffee its roasted smell.



A good tadka is another experiment. When spices meet hot ghee or oil, the heat helps release their aromatic oils. These molecules mix with the fat and spread flavour through the dish. This is why even a simple dal tastes so different after the tadka is added.



Fermentation gives Indian food its softness and tang. The batter for idlis and dosas comes alive because of helpful bacteria and yeasts. They produce acids and gases that make the food light and slightly sour. The same process makes homemade curd thick and creamy. This is everyday biochemistry happening in our kitchens.

Flavour is not just about taste. The smell of curry leaves or cardamom triggers memories and emotions. Our brain links these scents to family, festivals, and comfort. It is a biological reaction we often mistake for nostalgia.



Indian cooking shows how science and tradition work together. Our ancestors may not have used technical words, but they understood reactions, timing, and balance. Every spoon of pav bhaji or dal makhani is proof that science is not limited to the lab.

Sometimes, it lives right on the stove.

- Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
Singapore International School (Mumbai)



MY POWAI

WISHES YOU ALL A MERRY X'MAS
AND A VERY HAPPY NEW YEAR

Powai's hidden benches



Girija Menon

Powai has changed shape over the years. Towers keep rising, older spaces keep shrinking, and the pace of life seems to move in fast forward. Even so, the neighbourhood still holds a surprising amount of calm. The lake still steals the show. The gardens still carry a quiet dignity. And the green pockets inside IIT and the newer landscaped spaces in modern complexes still draw your eyes when you least expect it. This surprise factor is welcome, especially when concrete rule the roost leaving hardly any space for the greens that help us stay alive.

For me, a walk here is never just a walk. I often find myself drifting toward a bench. Sometimes it's deliberate. Sometimes it's instinct. I sit with a book, or let music fill the gaps in my thoughts, or just look around as the morning sun warms the skin in the softest way. Thoughts, always my companion, stringing them together a passion and no time is wasted on a bench doing "nothing". When the breeze picks up and brushes past, it feels like nature's way of saying sit a little longer. Time is limited and so one must walk away from the comforting bench only to come back again to be embraced in its reassuring lap.

The lake adds its own touch. Its surface changes mood through the day. Gentle ripples in the morning, a quiet shimmer by noon, and a molten glow when the sun begins to dip. The promenade around it has its own rhythm. There's always movement, but never chaos. As if the lake sets the tone and everyone adjusts to it without realising. Only wish it was more user friendly in a safe way for walking in the day and when its dark. Guess, hopefully that should change in the future.

Step away from the water and Powai reveals another charm. The internal roads, the by lanes, the alleys within housing complexes still hold on to old trees that have lived here longer than many of us. Trees so tall that their branches reach out and shake hands right in the middle, forming a long tunnel of shade. Stand under them for a moment and you feel wrapped in a hush that belongs more to thriving urban forest than a city battling construction dust.



Look at those arching leafy canopies from the right angle and the scene is almost unreal. Nature doing its quiet ballet while underneath traffic inches forward, honks impatiently and drivers try to beat the next signal. The contrast is odd but oddly beautiful. The trees stay steady. The breeze still moves. And if you catch that view at the right time, you forget for a second how difficult it is to simply cross a road.

This is where Powai's benches earn their meaning. They aren't just pieces of wood or metal dropped at random. They're witnesses. They've seen seasons shift, walkers age, friendships form, and strangers find comfort in short pauses. Whether you're alone or surrounded by noise, the bench offers a small promise: sit, breathe, allow yourself a moment. Inanimate? No they are the ones that give company with no judgement or questions asked.

In a city where space is fought for and silence is rare, these corners matter. They help us reset after dodging potholes, traffic cones, construction barricades and the endless dust that seems to hang in the air without permission. Even on days when walking feels like an obstacle course, a single bench under an old tree can make everything feel manageable again.

It's remarkable how something so simple can feel so complete. Four legs. A few sturdy planks. A supportive backrest. Two armrests that welcome you without fuss. Somehow this small structure becomes a companion, holding your weight when your mind feels heavy and giving you a moment to gather yourself.

Powai hides many such corners. You just need to look gently. Between the traffic, the noise and the rush, these benches quietly do their job. They offer a pocket of peace and a reminder that whatever the world throws at us, we still have places where we can slow down, feel the breeze, and listen to ourselves again.

Calm isn't missing. It's simply waiting for your eyes to pause long enough to see it.



(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)

Pṛthvī to Ākāśa: The Fivefold Foundation of all Creation (Part 5)
Ākāśa; The field that holds

"Emptiness of Ākāśa is not nothingness.
It is the field of all possibilities" ~ Anonymous



Palak Sardana

Ākāśa is the subtlest of all elements' and the most challenging one to comprehend. While other elements can be easily experienced via senses, Ākāśa can be understood as the emptiness in which all elements appear. Often translated as space, Ākāśa has a much wider meaning and representation as it is the field in which all possibilities exist & everything manifests & disappears into.

Taittirīya Upaniṣad declares that Ākāśa is the first element born out of Brahman. Its nature is very similar to its source; its subtle, all pervasive & the substratum of all existence. Despite the similarities, it is not Brahman itself but an evolute. While Brahman is 'Nirguna' (without qualities), śabda (sound/vibration) is the guna (quality) of Ākāśa. Functionally it's the "field" or space that allows movement and communication of subtler energies & impressions.

In the eight limbs of yoga prescribed by Sage Patanjali, the fifth limb, pratyahara (inward withdrawal of the senses) leads to the experience of Ākāśa element within. The practice involves a conscious redirection of attention away from external sensory inputs towards an internal state of space. It allows the awareness to turn inwards, leading to mental clarity, inner calm, and a profound sense of stillness. This internal focus makes us experience the emptiness, the very essence of Ākāśa element. It is in this space that thoughts, feelings and ideas rise and fall.

Need for pratyahara has never been as profound as it is in today's day and age. We live in the world of excesses. By design and orchestrated by the market forces, there is an incessant inflow of everything, right from information, to food, to entertainment & all other indulgences. Every marketer worth its salt is seeking your attention that converts into revenue for them.

A few years back, the then CEO of Netflix, Reed Hastings had openly declared that the biggest competitor for the company was people's sleep. And they haven't been off target in succeeding at it as these platforms are known to tap into the dopamine circuit that prompts people to binge watch in lieu of complete downtime.

Consistent consumption & distraction is leading to fast burnout. Our mind isn't designed to cater to so much stimulation. It is most productive when its calm and focused. For that, a purposeful withdrawal (pratyahara) from all thinking and doing needs to be built into our busy routines to experience the Ākāśa element which facilitates healing & rejuvenation.

There is enough scientific data to prove the efficacy of these short breaks. Psychologist Ernest Rossi developed & shared the concept of 'ultradian rhythm breaks' in his book '20-Minute Break'. These are short rest periods taken during the day, based on the theory that the human body and mind operate in natural energy cycles lasting approximately 90 to 120 minutes. During each cycle, there is a peak of high alertness and focus, followed by a natural dip in energy and cognitive function called the "ultradian trough". Taking a break during this natural downturn allows the body & mind to rest, recover, and reset, which helps prevent burnout and results in higher productivity, enhanced creativity, improved health, and better emotional well-being. During this downtime, the body clears metabolic waste & replenishes energy reserves, and the mind processes and integrates the day's experiences, leading to "ultradian healing response".

The most effective way of initiating deep restorative response during these breaks is shutting down the activity of mind. Mindfulness practices, yoga nidra, a short nap, spending time in nature etc can be extremely beneficial. Staying clear of screens, stimulants like coffee or energy drinks and taking mind off all work-related engagements is mandatory to set in the healing response. Idea again is to create 'space' between the busyness.

By practicing withdrawal (pratyahara) & fasting from external stimuli, mind is allowed to settle and align with the pervasive, intelligent spaciousness of Ākāśa.

While absorbing, thinking and analysing makes the mind sharper, its capacity truly expands when it is withdrawn inwards & given a break. The space experienced becomes the germinating ground for a different type of intelligence to emerge; the intuitive knowing. It manifests as surfacing of deeper insights, resonance derived solutions, intuitive alignment or dissonance with people or situations & grasping the essence without the need for knowing all the facts. It also sets the perfect foundation for further meditative practices leading to samadhi (state of complete dissolution of ego).

All potential exists in Ākāśa. It is the space of all possibilities, available to us at all times. While popular culture encourages doing, deep wisdom points towards periodic withdrawal. Your conscious choice can make all the difference. Ponder!



(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Winter wellness guide for Mumbai - tips for better immunity, nutrition and lifestyle



Nisha Singh

Winter's in Mumbai are mostly just the cooling down of warm and humid weather. But the month of December does bring its share of cool winds, crisp mornings and pleasant evenings. With this change in season, everyone you meet is either sneezing or coughing.

Even though temperature shifts are subtle, research has shown that even small drops in humidity as well as temperature can affect immunity, sleep, hydration and cravings. The good news though is that even a few small and smart changes in the way you eat, sleep, move and in general care for your body can help you feel healthier and navigate this cooler weather with ease.

The mild weather changes that Mumbai experiences matter. Why?

Even a shift of a few degrees in the temperature can lead to dry irritated skin, sinuses, and more propensity for infections since there is loss of humidity. Viruses spread more easily in dry air. Also the body's first line of defence - mucus is compromised due to dry nasal passages. On the other hand, since the weather is cool, the signal of thirst is reduced. But, water loss from the body continues in the form of breath and sweat. This often leads to dehydration, often mild but dehydration nonetheless. And even mild dehydration can trigger headaches, fatigue and dry skin. The body's natural clock or circadian rhythm also gets affected due to shorter days. Sun sets earlier and rises later during the winter months. This change throws the body's clock out of whack. Melatonin secretion is altered during this time which can often make the body feel sluggish and lethargic.

And hence, what you eat and how you eat during this season becomes extremely important. Winter is the time when you can enjoy naturally warm foods. Some of them are seasonal foods, available only during the colder months and others pack their punch during this season. These foods tend to not only provide warmth and nourishment to your body, but they also boost your immunity. Til or sesame seeds is one such food item. It is a rich source of calcium and omega 3 fatty acids. It supports healthy joints and skin. Sesame seeds moisturise the body from within. Jaggery aids digestion and provides minerals like iron and antioxidants. The body naturally craves rich food during this period and jaggery is a wonderful and seamless addition in the diet to not only improve digestion but also as a source of other important micronutrients.

Nuts and seeds like almonds, walnuts, pumpkin seeds, poopy seeds, chia seeds are a rich source of omega 3 and 6 fatty acids. They give deep nourishment to the body, are a good source of protein and pack a punch in terms of energy as well. A good method to add these in the diet are in the form of laddoos. Add Gond or Edible gum to the mix and you get an extremely nourishing and power packed snack. Edible gum or gond provides warmth to the body and is also good for digestion as well. Root vegetables like



sweet potatoes, carrots, and radishes are widely available in this season. From supporting eye health to boosting immunity they provide a variety of benefits to the body. Similarly seasonal fruits like Indian gooseberry or amla, berries like strawberry, mulberry, cape gooseberry, orange, sweet lime are abundant in this season. They are a rich source of vitamin C which supports immunity and boosts the body's defence mechanism. They are also rich in fiber, polyphenols and other antioxidants. Warming spices like turmeric, ginger or dried ginger powder, cinnamon, bay leaves, black pepper must be included in the diet for their warmth, immunity boosting and anti-inflammatory properties. Ensure that your breakfast options in the morning are warm and nourishing with a little bit of good fats added such as dailya with lots of vegetables and a topping of ghee, millet or moong dal chilla with herbs like mint and carrom seeds, milk boiled with a variety of dried fruits and a couple of dates. Ensure that there are foods which are rich in vitamin C in every meal to help keep the immunity high. There are a huge variety of seasonal vitamin C rich foods like Indian gooseberry, and more. Either include it as home made murabba or simply add it to your chutneys. Additionally, a dash of lemon juice on your salads or vegetables help too. Also remember to hydrate yourself well. Water intake generally goes down during the winter months. Include warm brews like herbal tea, ginger lemon tea, soups, and even flavoured warm water.

Lifestyle hacks that one can incorporate during the season are also a great way to boost immunity, provide energy and warmth to the body as well moisturise the body, inside out. Ensure exposure to sunlight on a regular basis. Include weekly warm oil body massages. This not only helps moisturise the body internally but also helps with achy joints and bones. Sesame seed oil is one of the best oils which can be used in this season. Massage yourself and sit in a sunny place for 20 minutes to reap maximum benefits. Include a session of yogasanas and pranayama for further advantage. Additionally, stick to a consistent sleep schedule. Add warm baths before bed to improve the sleep quality and help to induce sleep. Good sleep equates with good immunity.

Even though winters in Mumbai are mild and just for a few short weeks, they impact the body. A few smart and timely changes will help you navigate the cooler months without struggle. This season can be the reset for your health to prepare not only for the cold but the year ahead.

You can follow Dietitian Nisha on Instagram for nutrition & fitness tips and live interactive sessions at – nurtiwellness.by.dt.nishas

We at My Powai are taking our readers' queries related to Diet & Nutrition, which Ms. Nisha Singh will reply to in our forthcoming issues.

You can send your questions at: dietnutrition.queries@gmail.com

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

Flavours of Bengal: a symphony of soul and spice



Sherry Bhatnagar

To taste Bengali food is to journey through Bengal — from Kolkata's bustling kitchens to the serene courtyards of its countryside. Every dish tells a story, blending emotion with nostalgia. The comforting Aloo Posto, the delicate balance of Shukto, the festive warmth of Khichuri with Beguni, and the royal richness of Chanar Dalna or Doi Begun — each captures a different mood of Bengal. With mustard, poppy seeds, coconut, and ghee at its heart, Bengali cuisine balances spice and sweetness in perfect harmony — soulful, layered, and unforgettable. Let's begin this journey with the mouth- watering

Enchorer Dalna (Raw jackfruit curry)
The Bengali "Vegetarian Meat" Curry



Serves: 4
Prep Time: 20 minutes
Cook Time: 35 minutes

Ingredients
For the Jackfruit:

Raw jackfruit (Enchor):	500 g (cut into medium cubes, seeds included)
Water:	enough to parboil
Salt :	½ tsp
Turmeric:	¼ tsp
Mustard oil:	3 tbsp. (for frying the jackfruit

For the Curry:

Potatoes:	2 medium, peeled and cubed
Bay leaves:	2
Cumin seeds:	½ tsp
Ginger paste:	1½ tsp
Cumin powder:	1 tsp
Coriander powder:	½ tsp
Red chilli powder:	½ tsp (adjust to taste)
Turmeric powder:	½ tsp
Garam masala:	½ tsp
Sugar:	½ tsp
Salt to taste	
Mustard oil:	2 tbsp. (you can reuse some from frying the jackfruit)
Water:	1 to 1¼ cups (for gravy consistency)
Ghee:	1 tsp (optional, for finishing)

Preparation
- Prepare the Jackfruit by boiling it with salt and turmeric until just tender — do not overcook. Drain and set aside.
- Fry the Jackfruit & Potatoes by heating mustard oil until it smokes lightly. Fry the parboiled jackfruit pieces till lightly golden; remove. In the same oil, fry the potato cubes until golden and half-cooked; set aside.
- Make the Spice Base in the same pan, add bay leaves and cumin seeds; let them splutter. Add ginger paste, sauté till raw smell disappears. Add cumin, coriander, turmeric, red chilli powder, and a splash of water. Sauté till the masala releases oil and turns aromatic.
- Combine & Simmer by adding fried potatoes and jackfruit, tossing well to coat with the spice mix. Pour in warm water, season with salt and sugar, cover, and simmer till the potatoes are cooked and the gravy thickens.
- Finish the dish by sprinkling garam masala and a drizzle of ghee. Cover and let it rest for 5 minutes to absorb the flavours.

This dish tastes extra-ordinary when served hot with steamed gobindobhog rice. Just so irresistible.

Kosha Mangsho
(Bengali Mutton Curry)



Serves: 4
Prep Time: 20–25 min
Cook Time: 1–1.5 hrs

Ingredients

For the Marinade:

Mutton (bone-in preferred):	500 g
Yogurt :	3 tbsp.
Ginger-garlic paste:	2 tbsp.
Turmeric powder:	½ tsp
Red chili powder:	1 tsp
Salt :	1 tsp
Mustard oil :	2 tbsp.

For the Curry:

Mustard oil :	4 tbsp.
Bay leaves :	2
Green cardamom :	3–4 pods
Cloves:	3–4
Cinnamon stick:	1 small piece
Onions:	3 medium, thinly sliced
Ginger-garlic paste:	1 tbsp.
Tomato:	1 medium, finely chopped
Red chili powder :	1 tsp (adjust to taste)
Coriander powder :	1 tsp
Garam masala :	½ tsp
Sugar :	½ tsp (optional, balances spice)
Water:	1–1.5 cups

Method
- Marinate the Mutton by mixing mutton with yogurt, ginger-garlic paste, turmeric, red chili powder, salt, and 2 tbsp. mustard oil. Marinate for at least 1 hour (overnight is ideal).
- Fry Onions & Whole Spices: Heat mustard oil in a heavy-bottomed pan till smoking slightly. Add bay leaves, cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon; sauté for 30 seconds. Add sliced onions, fry till deep golden brown for richness. Add ginger-garlic paste and sauté till raw smell disappears.
- Cook the Mutton by adding marinated mutton, cook on high heat for 5–7 minutes until meat is seared. Add chopped tomato, red chili powder, coriander powder, and a little salt. Cook until tomato softens.
- Simmer & Reduce: Add 1–1.5 cups water, cover, and simmer on low heat for 45–60 minutes until mutton is tender and the gravy thickens. Stir occasionally, adjust water if needed to get a thick, luscious consistency.
- Finish by adding garam masala and sugar, simmer 2–3 minutes. Optionally, drizzle a teaspoon of mustard oil or ghee before serving for authentic aroma.

Serve hot with steamed basmati rice, luchi, or parathas. You really don't need anything in your platter to satisfy your hunger. Ye nahi khaya to kya khaya

(Sherry Bhatnagar is the founder of Anubhuti Food Ventures — a passionate food visionary, avid traveller and wellness advocate. With a deep-rooted belief that food is one of the purest expressions of care, she champions traditional Indian flavours, forgotten recipes, and nourishing meals. Through her writing, she invites readers to rediscover the emotional and cultural richness of home-cooked food, and the timeless wisdom that simmers in every regional dish.)

December 2025



Richa Pathak

Aries (March 21 – Apr 19) December helps you slow down mentally so you can make decisions with clarity instead of pressure. You may revisit an old plan with a stronger sense of direction, and work matters move forward steadily once you stop rushing. Personal relationships feel lighter as misunderstandings dissolve. **Lucky Color:** Flame Orange | **Lucky Day:** Monday | **Remedy:** Keep a red jasper stone on your desk to channel grounded confidence.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
This month brings emotional anchoring and practical wisdom. You may choose stability over impulse and finally set healthier boundaries at work and home. Finances improve through a disciplined routine rather than sudden opportunities. **Lucky Color:** Fern Green | **Lucky Day:** Saturday | **Remedy:** Burn a small camphor tablet in the evening to refresh energy and invite calm.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
December sharpens your thinking and helps you streamline scattered priorities. Conversations with key people open new pathways, and a delayed task finally reaches completion. Avoid multitasking too aggressively—focus brings better outcomes. **Lucky Color:** Soft Yellow | **Lucky Day:** Wednesday | **Remedy:** Write your weekly intentions on paper and keep it under a clear glass overnight to activate Mercury clarity.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
You feel more emotionally balanced this month, leading to wiser choices in work and family matters. A peaceful environment helps you heal old patterns, and financial matters begin stabilizing. Keep your schedule light and nurturing. **Lucky Color:** Pearl White | **Lucky Day:** Sunday | **Remedy:** Place two white candles beside your bed and light them together once a week for harmony.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
You operate from quiet strength—less drama, more direction. Recognition comes gradually but consistently, and a creative idea gains shape with support from the right person. Stay patient; slow wins matter most now. **Lucky Color:** Gold Bronze | **Lucky Day:** Tuesday | **Remedy:** Place a brass sun symbol in the east direction to enhance focus and visibility.

Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
This month encourages you to simplify your routine and cut down on unnecessary mental pressure. Work improves when you stop micromanaging every detail, and a healthier lifestyle choice brings immediate relief. **Lucky Color:** Sage Green | **Lucky Day:** Thursday | **Remedy:** Add a pinch of rock salt to your bathwater once a week to cleanse negativity.



Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
December strengthens your relationships and restores emotional equilibrium. You may take a firm stand on something you previously avoided, and that brings unexpected respect. Financial stability improves through balanced decisions. **Lucky Color:** Soft Coral | **Lucky Day:** Friday | **Remedy:** Keep a rose quartz stone near your workspace to maintain harmony.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
You release old emotional burdens and step into a more empowered version of yourself. Money flows better through practical decisions, and intuition guides you toward the right opportunities. **Lucky Color:** Wine Red | **Lucky Day:** Monday | **Remedy:** Burn a cinnamon stick weekly to refresh stagnant energy.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
Your optimism returns with new ideas and opportunities. Travel, learning, or collaborations may uplift your spirit. This is a good month to sketch future goals but avoid overpromising. **Lucky Color:** Royal Blue | **Lucky Day:** Sunday | **Remedy:** Keep a small world map or globe on your desk to activate Jupiter expansion.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
You step into a reflective yet productive phase. Work demands consistency, and your disciplined approach brings long-term benefits. Personal relationships need more softness than logic. **Lucky Color:** Charcoal | **Lucky Day:** Saturday | **Remedy:** Write one limiting belief on paper weekly and discard it to lighten emotional weight.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
December fuels fresh ideas and meaningful connections. You may collaborate with someone who broadens your perspective. Health improves with better hydration and rest. **Lucky Color:** Teal Blue | **Lucky Day:** Wednesday | **Remedy:** Place a bowl of uncooked rice in the north zone and change it weekly to boost career energy.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
Intuition becomes your compass and helps you navigate situations effortlessly. Creative work flows beautifully, and finances stabilise through mindful spending. Avoid emotional draining conversations. **Lucky Color:** Aqua Green | **Lucky Day:** Friday | **Remedy:** Apply a drop of sandalwood on your wrists before sleep for calm and spiritual alignment.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8452920640 & www.jyotishdham.com)